

TURF WARS
Devendra Fadnavis with Ajit Pawar at a meeting in Mumbai; (inset) Parth



ANI

> **"Prima facie, the facts coming forth were serious... and the signatories to the deal and the vendors had been named in the FIR... There is no reason for us to shield anyone"**
>
> **—DEVENDRA FADNAVIS**
> *Chief Minister, Maharashtra*

> **"Around three to four months ago, I came to know that something was underway. I said I would not tolerate such wrong-doings... and gave clear instructions to this effect"**
>
> **—AJIT PAWAR**
> *Deputy CM, Maharashtra*

claimed that in a meeting at the CM's official residence, an incensed Ajit threatened to walk out of the government and support it from outside. However, revenue minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule has denied this. Sachin Sawant, secretary, All India Congress Committee, has charged that Parth is being shielded. "This is a blatant abuse of power," he said, while seeking Ajit's resignation.

CUTTING DOWN PAWAR

The Parth Pawar controversy comes at a time when a senior BJP leader is facing flak over a similar land deal in Pune. Murlidhar Mohol, Union minister of state and Lok Sabha MP from Pune, has found himself in a spot over the sale of Seth Hirachand Nemchand Digambar Jain Boarding by Seth Hirachand Nemchand Smarak Trust at Model Colony to a construction company. Mohol was alleged to have connections with the developer, though he claimed he exited the firm before the deal, which the local court has now scrapped. The Jain community was up in arms over the sale of the around 3.5 acres of land, which also houses a Jain temple. Incidentally, among those leading the charge against Mohol was former Congress MLA Ravindra Dhangekar, now with the Shiv Sena.

The grapevine has it that, apart from deflecting public attention from the Mohol issue, the BJP is using the controversy to cut Ajit down to size—especially in his strongholds in and around Pune district and in western Maharashtra, where the party has traditionally been weak. It is also meant to pre-empt any unity moves between the two rival factions of the NCP, which would give the deputy CM greater heft